Introduction to Vicarious Trauma

Adapted from the *Introduction to Vicarious Trauma for Law Enforcement*

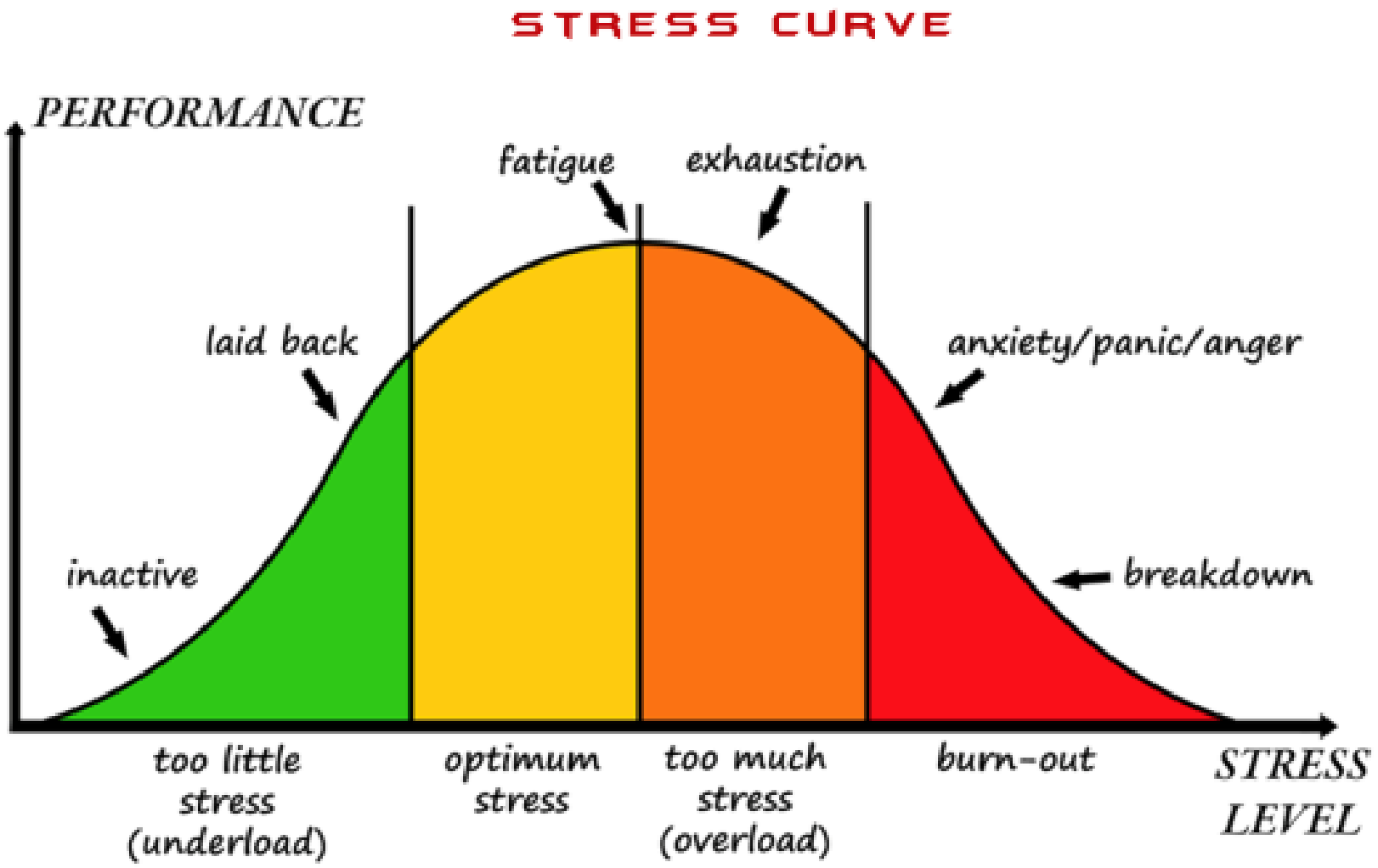
"The expectation that we can be immersed in suffering and loss daily and not be touched by it is as unrealistic as expecting to be able to walk through water without getting wet."

(Remen, 2006)

- Stress
  - Acute
  - Chronic
- Traumatic stress

- Vicarious trauma
- Critical incident stress
- Vicarious traumatization
- Secondary traumatic stress
- Compassion fatigue
- Burnout

Stress


STRESS CURVE
PERFORMANCE
fatigue
exhaustion
laid back
anxiety/panic/anger
inactive
breakdown
too little stress (underload)
optimum stress
too much stress (overload)
burn-out
STRESS LEVEL

The Stress Response

The brain and body's alarmed and alert response to a threatening situation.

Integral to the life of every living organism.

Our natural defense against danger.

Cumulative Stress

Cumulative stress reactions are more gradual form of stress reaction. Related to chronic stressors that “pile up” over time

Taking a Closer Look…

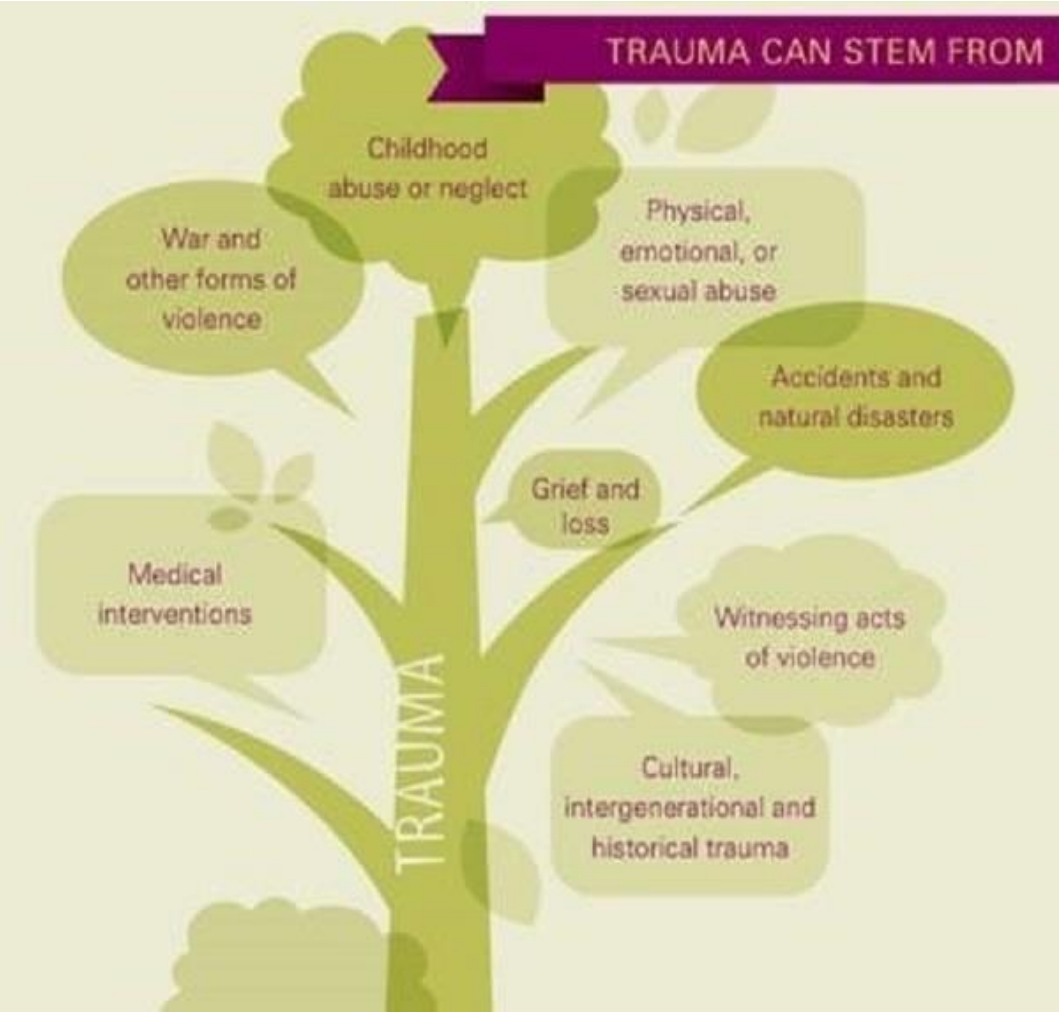
- Trauma
- Traumatic stress
- Vicarious traumatization

Traumatic Events

Human
Homicide
Sexual Assault
Assault/attack
War

Natural
Hurricane
Earthquake
Flood
Fire

On the Job
Fight or physical attack
Threat of physical harm
Accident



Trauma

- **Trauma** is an event that is outside one’s normal experience that causes intense fear and can exceed one's ability to cope.
- A traumatic event is more than a stressor; it is a threat to one's safety, security, and sense of well-being.
- Traumatic Events occur as:
  - A result of people’s behaviours or actions
  - Accidents
  - Natural Occurrences (tornados, hurricane, earthquake etc.)
- Exposure happens:
  - Directly – being involved in a critical incident
  - Indirectly – witnessing the traumatic experiences of another person

What Makes an Event Traumatic?

- It involves a threat—real or perceived—to one's physical or emotional well-being.
- It is overwhelming.
- It results in intense feelings of fear and lack of control.
- It leaves one feeling helpless.
- It changes the way a person understands the world, themselves, and others.

(American Psychiatric Association, 2000)

Defining Traumatic Stress

Traumatic stress is the stress response to a traumatic event(s) in which one is a victim or witness.

- Repeated stressful and/or traumatic events can chronically elevate the body's stress response.
- 4 percent of victims suffer about 44 percent of the offenses.

(Farrell and Pease, 1993)

Understanding the Difference Between Traumatic Stress and Vicarious Traumatization

Traumatic Stress

- Extreme emotionality or absence of emotion
- Fearful, jumpy, exaggerated startle response
- Flashbacks

Vicarious Traumatization

- Overly involved with or avoidance of victim/survivor
- Hypervigilance and fear for one's own safety (the world no longer feels safe and people can’t be trusted)
- Intrusive thoughts and images, or nightmares from victims’ stories

Work-Related Trauma Exposure

DIRECT exposure to trauma

- Post Traumatic Stress Disorder (PTSD)
- Post Traumatic Stress Symptoms
- Critical Incident Stress

INDIRECT exposure to trauma

- Post Traumatic Stress Disorder (DSM-V, 2013)
- Post Traumatic Stress Symptoms
- Empathic Strain
- Secondary Traumatic Stress Symptoms
- Vicarious Traumatization
- Compassion Fatigue

Change in World View

- Exposure to vicarious trauma leads to a change in world view. This is considered to be the result of **cumulative** exposure to traumatic stimuli.
- Empathy and empathic engagement with victims of trauma is a necessary skill we utilize to form connections, create a sense of safety, and express understanding to the people we help
  - Empathy is a good thing except it can shift our view of the world – depending on our initial view of the world the shift may be more or less profound
  - Our work experiences can challenge the belief that the world is relatively safe and predictable and people are good – we see how cruel people can be to each other

It's the shift in how we view the world, view others, and sense danger around us…

Secondary Traumatic Stress (STS)

"…the natural consequent behaviors and emotions resulting from knowing about a traumatizing event experienced by another…the stress resulting from helping or wanting to help a traumatized or suffering person."

(Figley, 1995)

Compassion Fatigue

"A combination of physical, emotional, and spiritual depletion associated with caring for patients in significant emotional pain and physical distress."

(Anewalt, 2009; Figley, 1995)

What About Burnout?

Burnout is “a state of physical, emotional, and mental exhaustion caused by long-term involvement in emotionally demanding situations.”

Examples of Vicarious Traumatization: Personal

- Physical
  - Rapid pulse/breathing, headaches, impaired immune system, fatigue, aches
- Emotional
  - Feelings of powerlessness, numbness, anxiety, guilt, fear, anger, depletion, hypersensitivity, sadness, helplessness, severe emotional distress or physical reactions to reminders
- Behavioral
  - Irritability, sleep and appetite changes, isolate from friends and family, self destructive behavior, impatience, nightmares, hypervigilance, moody, easily startled or frightened
- Spiritual
  - Loss of purpose, loss of meaning, questioning goodness versus evil, disillusionment, questioning prior religious beliefs, pervasive hopelessness
- Cognitive
  - Diminished concentration, cynicism, pessimism, preoccupation with clients, traumatic imagery, inattention, self doubt, racing thoughts, recurrent and unwanted distressing thoughts
- Relational
  - Withdrawn, decreased interest in intimacy or sex, isolation from friends or family, minimization of others' concerns, projection of anger or blame, intolerance, mistrust

(Adapted from J. Yassen in Figley, 1995)

Examples of Vicarious Traumatization: Professional

- Performance
  - Decrease in quality/quantity of work, low motivation, task avoidance or obsession with detail, working too hard, setting perfectionist standards, difficulty with inattention, forgetfulness
- Morale
  - Decrease in confidence, decrease in interest, negative attitude, apathy, dissatisfaction, demoralization, feeling undervalued and unappreciated, disconnected, reduced compassion
- Relational
  - Detached/withdrawn from co-workers, poor communication, conflict, impatience, intolerance of others, sense of being the “only one who can do the job”
- Behavioral
  - Calling out, arriving late, overwork, exhaustion, irresponsibility, poor follow-through

(Adapted from J. Yassen in Figley, 1995)

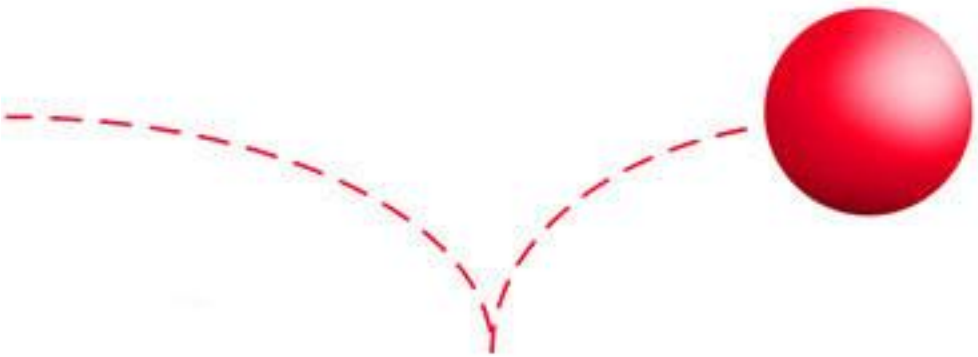
What is Self-Care?

Self-care is what people do for themselves to establish and maintain health, and to prevent and deal with illness.

It is a broad concept encompassing hygiene (general and personal), nutrition (type and quality of food eaten), lifestyle (sporting activities, leisure, etc.), environmental factors (living conditions, social habits, etc.) socio-economic factors (income level, cultural beliefs, etc.), and self-medication.'

(World Health Organization, 1998)

Resilience



Resilience is the process of **adapting** well in the face of adversity, trauma, tragedy, threats, or even significant sources of stress, such as family and relationship problems, serious health problems, or workplace and financial stressors.

It means “bouncing back” from difficult experiences.

(American Psychological Association)

Vicarious resilience

Involves the process of learning about overcoming adversity from the trauma survivor and the resulting positive transformation and empowerment through their empathy and interaction.

(Hernandez, Gangsei, and Engstrom, 2007)

Impact of Vicarious Resilience

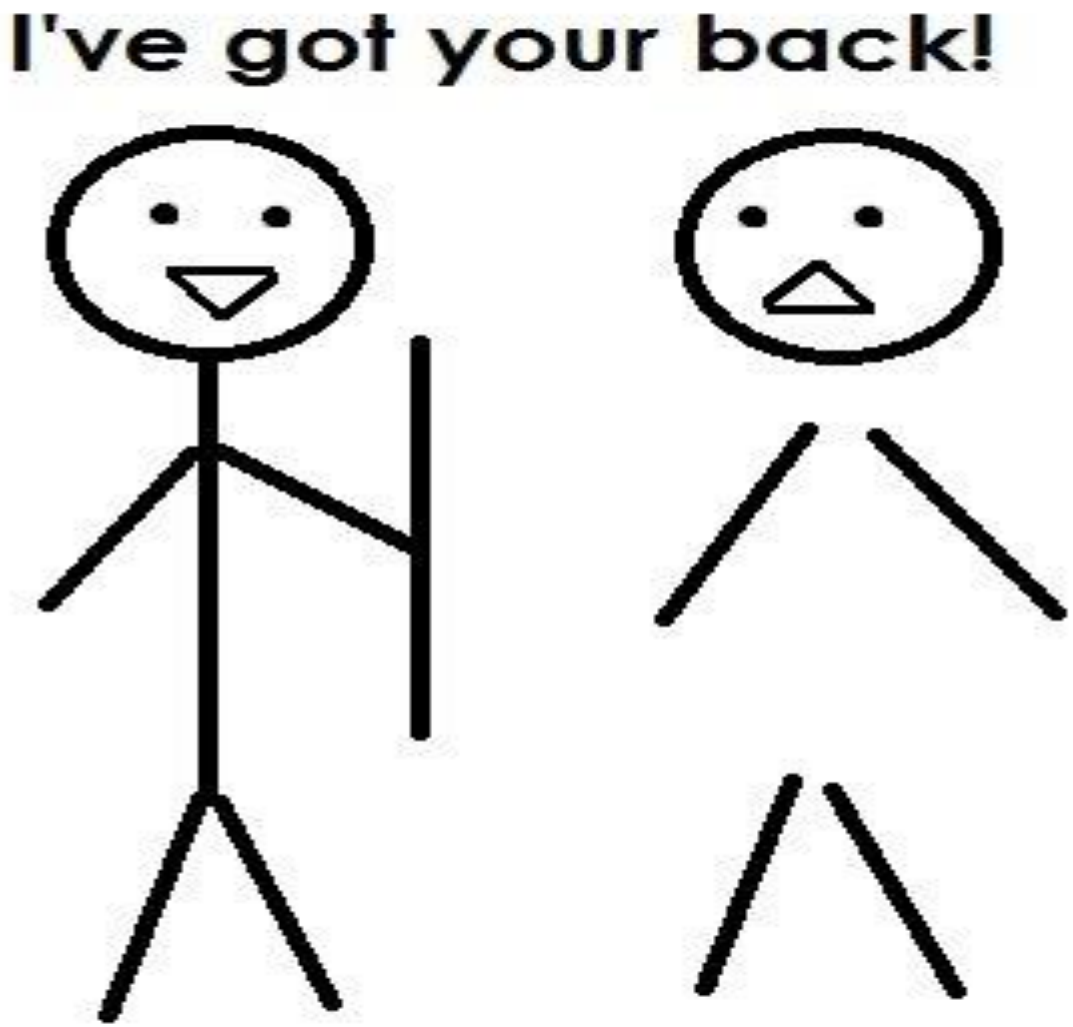
- Greater perspective and appreciation of own problems
- More optimistic, motivated, efficacious, and reenergized
- Increased sense of hope, understanding, and belief in the possibility of recovery from trauma and other serious challenges
- Profound sense of commitment to, and finding meaning from the work

(Hernandez, et al, 2007; Engstrom, et al, 2008)

Acknowledging the Positive:

Compassion Satisfaction

Vicarious Transformation



Look out for one another

References

- Bell, Holly, Shanti Kulkarni, and Lisa Dalton. 2003. “Organizational Prevention of Vicarious Trauma.” *Families in Society: The Journal of Contemporary Social Services* 84(4): 463–470. doi:10.1606/1044-3894.131.
- Berger, William, Evandro Coutinho, Ivan Figueira, Carla Marques-Portella, Mariana Pires Luz, Thomas C. Neylan, Charles R. Marmar, and Mauro Vitor Mendlowicz. 2011. “Rescuers at Risk: A Systematic Review and Meta-Regression Analysis of the Worldwide Current Prevalence and Correlates of PTSD in Rescue Workers.” *Social Psychiatry and Psychiatric Epidemiology* 47(6): 1001–1011. doi:10.1007/s00127-011-0408-2.
- Bonach, Kathryn, and Alex Heckert. 2012. “Predictors of Secondary Traumatic Stress Among Children’s Advocacy Center Forensic Interviewers.” *Journal of Child Sexual Abuse* 21(3): 295–314. doi:10.1080/10538712.2012.647263.
- Bride, Brian E., Melissa Radey, and Charles R. Figley. 2007. “Measuring Compassion Fatigue.” *Clinical Social Work Journal* 35(3): 155–163. doi:10.1007/s10615-007-0091-7.

References (cont.)

- Conrad, David, and Yvonne Kellar-Guenther. 2006. “Compassion Fatigue, Burnout, and Compassion Satisfaction Among Colorado Child Protection Workers.” *Child Abuse & Neglect* 30(10): 1071–1080. doi:10.1016/j.chiabu.2006.03.009.
- Cornille, Thomas A., and Tracy Woodard Meyers. 1999. “Secondary Traumatic Stress Among Child Protective Service Workers: Prevalence, Severity and Predictive Factors.” *Traumatology* 5(1): 15–31. doi:10.1177/153476569900500105.
- Engstrom, David, Pilar Hernandez, and David Gangsei. 2008. “Vicarious Resilience: A Qualitative Investigation Into Its Description.” *Traumatology* 14(3): 13–21. doi:10.1177/1534765608319323.
- Farrell, Graham, and Ken Pease. 1993. *Once Bitten, Twice Bitten: Repeat Victimisation and Its Implications for Crime Prevention.* London: Home Office Police Research Group.
- Figley, Charles R. 1995. *Compassion Fatigue: Coping With Secondary Traumatic Stress Disorder In Those Who Treat The Traumatized*. 1st edition. New York: Routledge.

References (cont.)

- Gilfus, Mary E. 1999. “The Price of the Ticket: A Survivor-Centered Appraisal of Trauma Theory.” *Violence Against Women* 5(11): 1238–1257. doi:10.1177/1077801299005011002
- Hernández, Pilar, David Gangsei, and David Engstrom. 2007. “Vicarious Resilience: A New Concept in Work With Those Who Survive Trauma.” *Family Process* 46(2): 229–241. doi:10.1111/j.1545-5300.2007.00206.x.
- Hudnall , Beth. 2002. “Measuring Compassion Satisfaction as Well as Fatigue: Developmental History of the Compassion Satisfaction and Fatigue Test.” In *Treating Compassion Fatigue*, 107–19. Psychosocial Stress Series, No. 24. New York, NY, US: Brunner-Routledge.
- Janoff-Bulman, Ronnie. 1992. *Shattered Assumptions: Towards a New Psychology of Trauma*. New York: Free Press.
- Kessler, Ronald C., Johan Ormel, Maria Petukhova, Katie A. McLaughlin, Jennifer Greif Green, Leo J. Russo, Dan J. Stein, et al. 2011. “Development of Lifetime Comorbidity in the World Health Organization World Mental Health Surveys.” *Archives of General Psychiatry* 68(1): 90–100. doi:10.1001/archgenpsychiatry.2010.180.

References (cont.)

- Mathieu, Françoise. 2012. “Compassion Fatigue.” In *Encyclopedia of Trauma: An Interdisciplinary Guide*, edited by Charles R. Figley, 1st edition, 904. Thousand Oaks, CA: SAGE Publications, Inc.
- Munroe, James F., Jonathan Shay, Lisa Fisher, Christine Makary, Kathryn Rapperport, and Rose Zimering. 1995. “Preventing Compassion Fatigue: A Team Treatment Model.” In *Compassion Fatigue: Coping with Secondary Traumatic Stress Disorder in Those Who Treat the Traumatized*, edited by Charles R Figley, 209–231. New York: Brunner-Routledge.
- Pearlman, Laurie Anne. 2016. “Headington Institute.” *Headington Institute*. Accessed November 8, 2016. www.headington-institute.org/.
- Remen, Rachel Naomi. 2006. *Kitchen Table Wisdom: Stories That Heal, 10th Anniversary Edition*. New York: Riverhead Books.
- Saakvitne, Karen W. 1999. *Risking Connection: A Training Curriculum for Working With Survivors of Childhood Abuse*. Lutherville, MD: Sidran Press.

References (cont.)

- Slattery, Suzanne M., and Lisa A. Goodman. 2009. “Secondary Traumatic Stress Among Domestic Violence Advocates: Workplace Risk and Protective Factors.” *Violence Against Women* 1 (11): 1358–1379. doi:10.1177/1077801209347469.
- Yassen, Janet. 1995. “Preventing Secondary Traumatic Stress Disorder.” In *Compassion Fatigue: Coping With Secondary Traumatic Stress Disorder In Those Who Treat The Traumatized*, edited by Charles R. Figley, 1 edition, 178–208. New York: Routledge.